

money, right? Wrong! The role of the spouse—the person who, usually, doesn't “work” at all—is critical.

Trouble is, few people are aware of this person's critical role in the creation of family money. Perhaps it's because the idea of traditional roles is not politically correct, but there's very little written about the role of the matriarch in most family wealth and estate-planning books.

But the fact is that a great family fortune requires a great matriarch. (Remember, it could be “patriarch” . . . but it is typically the woman who does this job.) And only with both of them “on the case” can they hope to create a family fortune.

Both must want to do so . . . because it takes discipline, sacrifice, vision, and a lot of hard work. First, the spouses must agree not to dissipate or consume the money. Then, they must work together to build the institutions, the culture, and the people that can hold it together.

For the family to be in harmony, the husband and wife need to be. They need to agree on their vision for the family, how they'll live and the plan for succession of the next generation.

So if you want to have family wealth, you need the right sort of family, and that begins with the right spouse, the one that has the potential to be a great matriarch.

Who is she?

The matriarch of the truly wealthy family is not like the “housewives” you see on reality TV shows. She's not a big gossip or a social climber. A matriarch is not a trophy wife. She doesn't spend her time focused on herself. She's not a big “consumer” of products. Instead, she's a “producer” of capable, confident children. She focuses on her children, making sure that they are emotionally provided for, that they are well-educated, capable individuals. She instills in them a sense of duty, to themselves and to the family.

The matriarch must be able to:

- Share in the family culture and be capable of passing it along. Indeed, she must play the leading role in creating it.
- Be capable of providing a stable home environment (even when the family is on the move).
- Understand and support the wealth-building strategy.